

GIVE GOD'S PART FIRST

"Honor the Lord from your wealth, and from the first of all your produce; so your barns will be filled with plenty, and your vats will overflow with new wine" (Proverbs 3:9-10).

The foundation for any family financial plan must be built upon God's Word. Throughout His Word, giving a portion of our wealth is described as essential to our receiving God's wisdom. This is not for God's benefit, but for ours. The willingness to surrender to God a portion of what we have is the external evidence of an internal commitment.

There will never be "enough" to give. You must simply commit that portion to God and adjust the rest accordingly. When you do this willingly and obediently, God promises to provide His wisdom to manage the rest. "There is one who scatters, yet increases all the more, and there is one who withholds what is justly due, but it results only in want" (Proverbs 11:24).

DEVELOP GOOD RECORDS

It is impossible to manage your money without keeping good financial records. These include:

- (1) A good double-entry ledger where all checks and bank expenses are posted.
- (2) A ledger-type checkbook (or even better, one with a carbon copy).
- (3) A budget book defining the amounts to be spent on each household expense each month. This should be simple but complete. We will review the specifics of budgeting in more detail a little later.

DIVIDE THE RESPONSIBILITIES IN THE HOME

It is important for both husband and wife to recognize their joint responsibilities in the home. It is sometimes taught that finances are the husband's sole responsibility. That simply is not true. God put two different people together, neither of whom is superior nor inferior, only different.

The husband is the final authority in the home, but God also